in favor of a position that, however painful, can be encapsulated in a single sentence: We have not been given the lead in the cosmic drama.

Perhaps someone else has. Perhaps no one else has. In either case, we have good reason for humility.

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*St. Augustine, in *The City of God*, says, "As it is not yet six thousand years since the first man … are not those to be ridiculed rather than refuted who try to persuade us of anything regarding a space of time so different from, and contrary to, the ascertained truth?… We, being sustained by divine authority in the history of our religion, have no doubt that whatever is opposed to it is most false." He excoriates the ancient Egyptian tradition that the world is as much as a hundred thousand years old as "abominable lies." St. Thomas Aquinas, in the *Summa Theologica*, flatly states that "the newness of the world cannot be demonstrated from the world itself." They were so *sure*.

*Our universe is *almost* incompatible with life—or at least what we understand as necessary for life: Even if every star in a hundred billion galaxies had an Earthlike planet, without heroic technological measures life could prosper in only about 10^{-37} the volume of the Universe. For clarity, let's write it out: only 0.000 000 000 000 000 000 000 000 000 000 000 000 1 of our universe is hospitable to life. Thirty-six zeroes before the one. The rest is cold, radiation-riddled black vacuum.

*For such ideas, words tend to fail us. A German locution for Universe is [*das*] *All—which makes the inclusiveness quite unmistakable. We might say that our universe is but one in a "Multiverse," but I prefer to use "Cosmos" for everything and "Universe" for the only one we can know about.*